

“... these **infamous associations**
... rob, they murder, they whip
...”
...

FROM AN ARTICLE ENTITLED “WORSE THAN SLAVERY,” *HARPER’S WEEKLY*,
1874

Politics and the White League

Following the suppression of the Klan, white Southerners turned to the Democratic Party to achieve “home rule.” In 1867, Democratic leaders encouraged voters to shun elections for the state constitutional conventions, where new constitutions enshrining universal manhood suffrage, or the right of Black men to vote, were to be written. They also boycotted the elections to ratify these new progressive constitutions. But resistance failed to stop the constitutions from being ratified, and most Southern states were readmitted to the Union by 1868.

Organizations similar to the Klan appeared, including the White League, a paramilitary operation that disavowed secrecy in favor of open political activity and armed intimidation and election fraud. In April 1873, a white mob killed between 60 and 100 Black men occupying a courthouse in Colfax, Louisiana, an event known as the Colfax Massacre. Such violence maintained pressure on Republican organizers in the South. Through legal and illegal efforts, Southern whites worked to end Reconstruction.